



FROM ZERO TO PRO - MODULE 05

Eggs, Dairy & Breakfast Mastery

Eggs are the classic test of a cook; gentle heat and timing are everything.

Week 9 - watch, study, cook, reflect

By the end of this module

1 Cook eggs every classic way: scrambled (French & American), omelet, poached, fried, boiled.

2 Understand custards, curds, and the danger of overheating dairy.

3 Make a simple pan crepe and pancake batter.

4 Plate a clean breakfast to order.

LESSON 5.1

Understanding the Egg

Objective: Know how egg proteins behave so you can control texture.

Key points

- Whites set ~150-160 deg F; overheating makes eggs rubbery and weepy.
- Most egg failures are simply too much heat - go gentle and stop early.
- Eggs leaven, thicken, emulsify, and bind across all of cooking.
- Fresh eggs poach best; older whites whip to greater volume.

Watch out for

- Cooking eggs over high heat 'to save time'.
- Walking away - eggs go from perfect to overcooked in seconds.
- Salting whipped whites early, which slows the foam.

LESSON 5.2

Scrambles and Omelets

Objective: Make soft scrambles and a clean rolled omelet.

Key points

- Low heat plus constant stirring = small, creamy curds.
- Pull eggs off heat slightly underdone; carryover finishes them.
- A French omelet is pale and tender, with no browning.
- Season at the end so salt does not toughen the eggs early.

Technique

- 1 Beat**
Whisk eggs until uniform; no streaks of white.
- 2 Heat gently**
Melt butter in a nonstick pan over low-medium heat.
- 3 Stir**
Stir constantly for creamy curds, easing off as they set.
- 4 Roll**
Tilt the pan and roll the omelet onto the plate, seam down.

LESSON 5.3

Poached, Fried, and Boiled Eggs

Objective: Cook eggs to order: runny poach, crisp fry, jammy boil.

Key points

- Poach fresh eggs in barely-simmering water; 3-4 minutes for a runny yolk.
- Fried eggs: low and covered for sunny-side-up; hotter for crispy edges.
- Boiled: ~6-7 min jammy, ~9-12 min fully set, then ice-shock.
- Ice-shocking stops carryover and eases peeling.

Technique

- 1 Swirl**
Create a gentle vortex in barely-simmering water.
- 2 Slip**
Lower the egg in close to the water; let the white wrap the yolk.
- 3 Time**
Cook 3-4 minutes for a runny center.
- 4 Lift**
Remove with a slotted spoon and drain on a towel.

LESSON 5.4

Custards and the Griddle

Objective: Make a smooth custard and cook crepes and pancakes.

Key points

- Temper eggs - add hot liquid slowly - to avoid scrambling.
- Cook custard to nappe (~170-180 deg F): it coats the back of a spoon.
- Strain custards for a silky texture; chill promptly.
- Pancakes: flip once when bubbles form and edges set.

Technique

- 1 Temper**
Whisk a little hot milk into the yolks to warm them.
- 2 Return**
Pour back into the pot over low heat.
- 3 Stir to nappe**
Stir constantly until it coats a spoon.
- 4 Strain and chill**
Pass through a sieve and cool quickly.

Practice & homework

1

Make a rolled French omelet with no browning; repeat until clean.

2

Poach two eggs with set whites and runny yolks.

3

Make creme anglaise without scrambling it; strain and chill.

Watch & learn (free)



[Jacques Pepin - The Secret to Perfectly Cooked Eggs \(KQED\)](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=As6AY_ChJuI)

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[Jacques Pepin - Techniques & More \(KQED\)](https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PL435B8FOCB00AF764)

<https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PL435B8FOCB00AF764>



[Gordon Ramsay \(knife & cooking basics\)](https://www.youtube.com/@gordonramsay)

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Next up - Module 06: Vegetables, Grains & Legumes

FROM ZERO TO PRO - THE SELF-TAUGHT CHEF PROGRAM